

UTT Chapter 12 Assignment

Hello there!

This weekend was *awesome*! The gang met up at the front lawn to play some ultimate Frisbee while we still have a warm spell. I was not expecting so many really good players here, but boy was I wrong! We had three different teams, so each team alternated games. After about four hours, everyone was wiped out. Sarah didn't play, so she brought smoothies for everyone. We really needed them after all that running. Nathan and I had an epic moment where he threw the Frisbee over the head of the tallest guy, and I miraculously caught it while running into the in-zone. Paige was taking pictures during all the games, and she managed to capture that play on camera. Needless to say, that picture will be on my wall as soon as she prints it. Overall, we placed second, but it was still a blast. If it doesn't snow next weekend, we might meet up again for round two.

School has not been busy lately, so I have had more time to just relax and catch up on some reading. I finished C. S. Lewis's Space Trilogy last week. Have you read it? If not, you definitely should. C. S. Lewis is a fantastic author. My favorite was the last book, *That Hideous Strength*. All of the bioethics stuff was really interesting, especially since I am taking biology. It is crazy to imagine what science could do without the ethical boundaries like we talked about a few weeks ago.

In my Intro to Psychology class, we have been learning about theories of human behavior. This week, the class focused specifically on behaviorism. Behaviorism is basically an approach in psychology that sees humans as stimulus receptors who respond in predetermined ways to their environment. B.F. Skinner, the founder of behaviorism, taught that everything is learned through interactions with the environment. We are shaped solely by the world around us. Apparently this is not as prominent now as it used to be.

Sarah, Mark, Paige, and I were talking about it over coffee. I guess Sarah took the class last semester. She began talking about the third-force psychology. In an effort to avoid looking ignorant, I didn't bother asking her what "third force psychology" was. Mark went on to say that behaviorism doesn't make sense because it cannot account for free will. He mentioned Pavlov and tied his research to the dialectic. **How does Secularism view psychology?** And **how does Marxism view psychology?** Paige chimed into the conversation saying we cannot understand the self as a unified entity. Instead, we have a multiplicity of selves. I don't really understand what that means. **How does Postmodernism view psychology?** As I was talking with Mark and Paige, I began to wonder how Nathan, as a New Spiritualist, would think about the soul. **How does New Spirituality view the concept of the self?** I know the Bible teaches that human beings are fallen and composed of immaterial souls. I bet this affects how we practice psychology. **What is the Christian view of psychology?**

Well it is already past midnight here. I guess that means I should get some sleep before my 8:30 a.m. class tomorrow. Thanks again for all your help! You're the best.

Talk to you soon,
-Doug

Doug brought up five different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. How does Secularism view psychology?

Secular psychology is shaped by two fundamental assumptions about mankind: We are purely physical entities and we are highly evolved animals produced by millions of years of naturalistic evolution. These two assumptions formed the basis for the three forces of Secular psychology: Skinner's theory of behaviorism, Freud's method of psychoanalysis, and Maslow's assumptions regarding the hierarchy of needs and **self-actualization**. To a large extent, the first two forces have fallen out of favor with today's Secular psychologists. The assumptions behind third force psychology are that (1) man is naturally good; (2) psychological illness is due to physical, social, and mental processes rather than spiritual ailments; and (3) mental health is restored when the aforementioned factors are properly balanced (self-actualization). [12.3]

2. How does Marxism view psychology?

Marxism's psychology is also based on materialism. The struggle for Marxists was finding a materialistic psychology that also allowed for free will. Since behaviorism precludes free will, it was ultimately rejected. As Marxists saw it, free will is a necessary component for starting a social revolution. If there is no free will, then Marxists can't convince the polis to join the communist fight. Marxists ultimately favored Pavlov's approach of **classical conditioning**—a training technique that pairs a naturally occurring stimulus and response with an unrelated stimulus, so that eventually, the unrelated stimulus is able to produce the desired response in absence of the natural stimulus. Pavlov demonstrated how this technique could be used to manipulate animals. Marxists believed they could ultimately use it to elicit the desired behavioral response from society—a proletariat revolution. In the end, a communist state would provide the proper mental health that everyone needed. [12.4]

3. How does Postmodernism view psychology?

Postmodernism denies that human beings have any identifiable essence, continuous self, or unified soul. Instead, Postmodern psychology teaches a **decentered self**—the belief that human beings are social constructions with a multiplicity of "selves." We assume a variety of personalities in different settings, with distinctive people, and throughout the various stages of our lives. No one persona can adequately define who we truly are.

As Postmodernists see it, the idea of a naturally whole and coherent soul—or even a stable and unified self—is only an illusion that keeps us in line with the status quo. What counts as aberrant behavior, or even abhorrent

behavior, is merely an arbitrary limitation set by society. Since human beings are just a set of socially constructed selves, a healthy person will resist society's attempts to define him. Instead of letting society dictate what counts as sane or normal, Postmodern psychology encourages people to be whoever they want to be. [12.5]

4. How does New Spirituality view the concept of the self?

New Spiritualists adhere to what has become known as **fourth force psychology**—a school of psychology that attempts to integrate aspects of transcendent religious teachings within the framework of modern psychology. For New Spiritualists, the idea of “self” is thought to lead to an unhealthy focus on “ego.” According to New Spirituality, it is only when we rid ourselves of our inward focus and tap into higher consciousness through meditation that we can be released from psychological unease. By emptying ourselves, we find that we are ultimately part of God and not distinct individuals. By letting go of all distinctions, we grow in consciousness and wellness. If we want physical, spiritual, and mental healing, then we must strive to achieve higher consciousness. [12.6]

5. What is the Christian view of Psychology?

Christianity adheres to the belief that men and women are created in the image of God. This fact requires that we recognize the significance of the spiritual aspects of human beings. The mind is a supernatural consciousness, not a byproduct of the physical brain. According to Christianity, human beings have a two-fold nature, **mind/body dualism**—the belief that human beings are composed of immaterial minds and material bodies. While materialists cannot easily account for free will or identity, Christianity can. In addition, Christianity is able to address the true nature of psychological suffering—sin. [12.8]